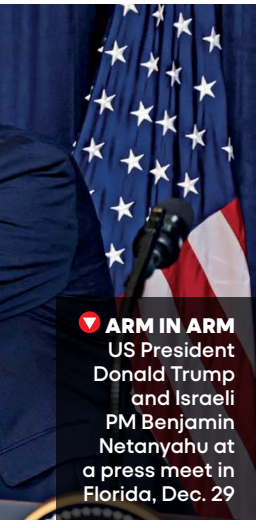


HEAVING STREETS Pro-regime supporters after the ceasefire announcement, Tehran, Apr. 8



ARM IN ARM US President Donald Trump and Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu at a press meet in Florida, Dec. 29

THE COMPETING PROPOSALS FOR PEACE



How Iran's 10-point plan of Apr. 7 compares with America's 15-point proposal of Mar. 25 on vital points

THE NUCLEAR ISSUE

IRAN

- Acceptance of Iran's uranium enrichment rights
- Termination of resolutions by the IAEA Board of Governors

US

- Iran to stop all uranium enrichment
- Handover of enriched uranium stockpiles to the IAEA and allow full monitoring
- Dismantle major nuclear facilities of Natanz, Fordow and Isfahan
- Permanent commitment not to develop nuclear weapons
- US support for electricity generation at Bushehr nuclear plant

STRAIT OF HORMUZ

IRAN

- Continued Iranian control over Strait of Hormuz

US

- Reopen the Strait of Hormuz unconditionally

CONDUCT OF WAR AND 'PROXIES'

IRAN

- US commitment against any future aggression
- Withdrawal of US forces; cessation of hostilities, including US/ Israeli action against 'resistance groups'
- Compensation to Iran for war losses

US

- Stop/ limit ballistic missile programmes
- End strikes on neighbouring energy infrastructure
- End support for proxy groups like the Hezbollah and the Houthis

SANCTIONS AND RESOLUTIONS

IRAN

- Lifting of all primary and secondary sanctions
- Termination of anti-Iran resolutions by UN Security Council
- Ratification of all new demands in a binding UNSC resolution
- Unfreezing of all Iranian assets abroad

US

- Making removal of US sanctions and UN snapback mechanism conditional upon Iran's good conduct

A GULF-SIZED PREDICAMENT

This is the Gulf's central dilemma: to contain Iran but not destabilise it beyond control. Complicating this calculus is a parallel anxiety, seldom expressed openly but felt widely. Of an unchecked Israel, emboldened by its recent military campaigns and savage force in Gaza, emerging as a dominant regional power. The images of destruction in Gaza have inflamed public opinion across the Arab world, placing governments in a fragile position. So, while they must preserve strategic ties with America and reach quiet security understandings with Israel, they cannot appear complicit in actions abhorred deeply among their own people.

Walking this tightrope requires careful calibration. Gulf states are likely to double down on multi-layered diplomacy, by maintaining channels with Iran even as they support its containment, while engaging the US to ensure any regional security architecture does not tilt decisively in Israel's favour. Simultaneously, they may seek to rebalance through broader partnerships with major and middle powers such as China, Europe, Russia and India to reduce dependence on any single axis.

There is also a growing emphasis on de-escalation frameworks: backchannel talks, crisis hotlines and confidence-building measures that can prevent flare-ups from spiralling into wider conflict and avoid the dangerous brinkmanship of the past six weeks. Crucially, the Gulf will continue to invest in economic interdependence and regional integration, using trade, energy cooperation and infrastructure linkages as stabilising anchors. If there is one takeaway from our experts' assessments, it is that the Gulf will not emerge from this conflict unchanged.

For the present, though, the immediate uncertainties remain unresolved: whether the Strait of Hormuz will stay open, whether Iran will retain leverage over global energy flows or whether this conflict will settle into a prolonged, low-intensity disruption. As one expert puts it with stark clarity: there are no winners in this conflict, only degrees of loss. The drones may have fallen silent for the moment, but the Gulf remains wounded. Whether this pause paves a pathway to peace or proves to be a mere prelude to another cycle of conflict will shape the future not just of the region, but of the world. ■